

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Manufacturing English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Production Flow and Daily Management

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

02 Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

03 Defects, Scrap, and Rework

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

04 Root Cause and Corrective Action

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

06 EHS and Safety Communication

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

Clarify missing information before responding.

08 Shift Handoffs and Escalation

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Production Flow and Daily Management

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

SITUATION

A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

throughput - Amount of work, patients, goods, cases, or transactions completed in a period of time.

cycle time - The time needed to complete one defined production or work cycle.

constraint - A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible.

downtime - Time during which equipment or a service is unavailable for its intended work.

3. Notice the language

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Compare this wording: Everything is progressing well.

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give a useful status update

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence says a review is finished?
 - A. The team plans to complete the review.
 - B. The team has completed the review.
 - C. The team is completing the review.
2. Which update distinguishes a plan from a confirmed fact?
 - A. Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.
 - B. Delivery is confirmed for Friday because we planned it.
 - C. The delivery plan proves that arrival will be Friday.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A 160-unit gap with downtime still under review

Fictional daily production meeting: the line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target; 40 minutes of downtime are logged, but the cause is unconfirmed.

01 • Production supervisor: We produced eight hundred forty units against a thousand-unit target, leaving a gap of one hundred sixty.

02 • Operations manager: Does the forty minutes of downtime explain the entire gap to target?

03 • Production supervisor: That hasn't been established. Downtime is recorded, but its cause and contribution are still under review.

04 • Operations manager: What can we report as completed work rather than an assumption about the constraint?

05 • Production supervisor: The output count and downtime duration are confirmed. The explanation for the shortfall remains pending.

06 • Operations manager: Should we promise to recover all one hundred sixty units during the next shift?

07 • Production supervisor: Not without assessing capacity and the unresolved issue. I can request a recovery-plan review.

08 • Operations manager: Please include cycle-time evidence if it helps explain the actual throughput limitation.

09 • Production supervisor: I'll bring the verified log and separate measured performance from proposed explanations.

10 • Operations manager: Good. We'll review the next update before committing to a recovery quantity or naming the cause.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A queue grows between assembly and inspection

Separate fictional production case: assembly completed 120 units, inspection completed 90, and 30 newly assembled units await inspection; no earlier queue is included.

01 • Line leader: Assembly completed one hundred twenty units, and inspection completed ninety from this group.

02 • Production planner: Then can I describe all one hundred twenty as finished output for dispatch?

03 • Line leader: No. Thirty still await inspection, so assembly completion is not the same as dispatch readiness.

04 • Production planner: Does that prove inspection is our permanent production constraint rather than a temporary queue?

05 • Line leader: Not from this snapshot. We need the process history and capacity information before making that conclusion.

06 • Production planner: I'll report the thirty-unit inspection queue separately from the completed inspection count.

07 • Line leader: Please keep the scope clear: these figures concern this group, not an earlier backlog.

08 • Production planner: Can you confirm the next inspection-status checkpoint before I update the downstream schedule?

09 • Line leader: I'll ask the inspection lead and return a verified update rather than estimate an unapproved release time.

10 • Production planner: Understood. I'll keep throughput stages distinct and avoid treating unfinished work as available inventory.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The line restarted, but the loss is not explained

Separate fictional daily-management exercise: line B restarted at 11:10 after a 15-minute stop; the stop reason and lost-output estimate remain unverified.

01 • Shift supervisor: Line B restarted at eleven ten after a fifteen-minute stop. The cause is still being checked.

02 • Production analyst: Can I close the downtime investigation now that the line is running again?

03 • Shift supervisor: Restart is a confirmed operational status, not a completed explanation of the stop.

04 • Production analyst: Should I calculate lost output using yesterday's cycle time as though it applied today?

05 • Shift supervisor: Only as an explicitly labeled estimate if appropriate; today's actual conditions haven't been verified here.

06 • Production analyst: I'll keep the confirmed duration separate from any proposed loss calculation.

07 • Shift supervisor: Good. Don't describe the restart as proof that the underlying constraint has disappeared permanently.

08 • Production analyst: What next update do you need for the afternoon daily-management discussion?

09 • Shift supervisor: The verified reason, relevant production conditions, and any remaining action owned by the responsible team.

10 • Production analyst: I'll gather those details and report completed recovery separately from the pending investigation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Production Flow and Daily Management

A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

Scenario 2 | Output recorded in different units

A fictional morning board shows 60 boxes while the production target is 600 individual units. The number of units per box has not been confirmed. Give a status explanation and request the missing conversion before stating performance against target.

Role A: Production analyst: identify the measurement mismatch.

Role B: Shift leader: confirm the need to verify packing quantity before comparing output.

Possible opening: The board counts boxes, but the target counts individual units, so we need the verified conversion.

Success checks

- Keep the two measurement units distinct.
- Do not invent a conversion or performance result.
- Agree who verifies the pack quantity and updates the board.

Add a complication: A manager suggests assuming ten units per box because that was last month's format.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

SITUATION

A team observes repeated waiting for shared tools during a kaizen event. A supervisor blames slow operators.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

kaizen - Continuous improvement through recurring examination and adjustment of work processes.

standard work - The documented current method for performing a task consistently.

waste - Activity or material that consumes resources without adding the intended value.

value stream - The sequence of activities involved in delivering a product or service to a customer.

3. Notice the language

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

In [specific situation], I noticed ...

The effect was ... What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Compare this wording: You are always careless.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give feedback people can use

4. Check the language

1. Which feedback begins with observable behavior?
 - A. The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date.
 - B. The last two updates seemed less professional than usual.
 - C. I think the team needs to be more committed to the updates.
2. Which follow-up invites useful information before agreeing on support?
 - A. Can you promise this will never happen again?
 - B. Would another reminder solve this problem?
 - C. What is making this part of the task difficult?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Waiting for shared tools, not slow operators

Fictional kaizen discussion: repeated waits for shared tools were observed, but the supervisor has described the operators as slow.

01 • Improvement facilitator: We observed repeated waiting for shared tools. Calling the operators slow doesn't describe that process problem.

02 • Production supervisor: What feedback would help the team without sounding like a personal criticism of my comment?

03 • Improvement facilitator: Say what happened: work paused while the tools were unavailable, which interrupted the observed flow.

04 • Production supervisor: Should we immediately buy another set and call the waste removed from the value stream?

05 • Improvement facilitator: We should examine the pattern and proposed change first. The observation doesn't establish the best solution.

06 • Production supervisor: I'll ask the team to show where the waiting occurs during the standard work.

07 • Improvement facilitator: Good. Invite their explanation of access and sequencing instead of assuming a motivation problem.

08 • Production supervisor: Then we can propose a small reviewed improvement and define what we will observe afterward.

09 • Improvement facilitator: Exactly. Kaizen feedback should connect the observed interruption to a practical next step.

10 • Production supervisor: I'll restate the issue as tool availability and keep any claim of improvement dependent on the follow-up evidence.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A long walk to the label printer

Separate fictional improvement case: an observer recorded six trips from packing to a shared label printer during one hour; distances and causes of repeat trips are unmeasured.

01 • Lean coordinator: I observed six trips to the label printer in one hour, interrupting the packing sequence.

02 • Packing supervisor: Are you saying the packers are walking too slowly between their tasks?

03 • Lean coordinator: No. My feedback concerns repeated travel in the process, not the speed or effort of individuals.

04 • Packing supervisor: Could we call moving the printer closer a confirmed time-saving change right away?

05 • Lean coordinator: It is an option to assess. We haven't measured distance, reasons for repeat trips, or the resulting time.

06 • Packing supervisor: I'll ask the packers which trips are necessary and where the standard work creates additional travel.

07 • Lean coordinator: Please use concrete examples so we can distinguish needed movement from possible waste.

08 • Packing supervisor: Then we'll discuss an appropriately reviewed layout trial and a clear comparison method.

09 • Lean coordinator: Good. Keep the observation separate from a promised improvement percentage.

10 • Packing supervisor: I'll bring the team's explanation to the kaizen discussion and agree how to evaluate any proposed change.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A handoff interrupts standard work

Separate fictional kaizen observation: an operator stopped the packing sequence twice to answer status questions already shown on the team's board.

01 • Team leader: I interrupted packing twice to ask for status that was already on the board.

02 • Improvement coach: That's a specific observation. What effect did those interruptions have on the standard-work sequence?

03 • Team leader: The operator stopped the sequence to answer me; I didn't measure the total delay.

04 • Improvement coach: Then describe the interruption without inventing a time loss or blaming the operator.

05 • Team leader: Could I try checking the board first and only ask when the status needs clarification?

06 • Improvement coach: That is a practical behavior to test, provided the board is kept current.

07 • Team leader: We haven't checked its update reliability yet, so I'll ask the team about that dependency.

08 • Improvement coach: Good. Continuous improvement should consider the information process as well as the individual interaction.

09 • Team leader: I'll explain what I observed and agree a trial for the next daily-management cycle.

10 • Improvement coach: Then review whether interruptions changed, without assuming the proposed habit eliminates all waste in the value stream.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

A team observes repeated waiting for shared tools during a kaizen event. A supervisor blames slow operators.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Second round: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Model for scenario 1: The observed delay occurs while people wait for shared tools. Let's examine tool availability and layout before attributing the issue to individual speed. Could we test a revised arrangement?

Scenario 2 | A suggestion dismissed before explanation

During a fictional kaizen meeting, a technician proposes moving a shared gauge. The supervisor replies that the team always complains before hearing the reason. Practice feedback on the interruption and invite the technician's process observation.

Role A: Improvement facilitator: describe the supervisor's actual remark and its effect on the discussion.

Role B: Production supervisor: acknowledge the interruption and propose a more useful follow-up question.

Possible opening: When the suggestion was called complaining before the reason was heard, we lost the chance to examine the process issue.

Success checks

- Use the supplied behavior rather than label the supervisor's character.
- Separate hearing a suggestion from approving a change.
- Agree a focused question about the observed workflow.

Add a complication: The supervisor says accepting feedback means agreeing to move the gauge immediately.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Defects, Scrap, and Rework

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A quality report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework. The manager needs to understand the different consequences.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

defect - Failure, flaw, nonconformance, or error that prevents an output from meeting requirements.

scrap - Material or product that cannot be used as intended and is removed from the relevant production output.

rework - Additional processing intended to make nonconforming work meet requirements.

containment - Action intended to limit the spread or effect of a problem while it is addressed.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - B. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - C. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - B. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - C. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Scrap and pending rework are different outcomes

Fictional quality review: a report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework; separate quantities and final rework outcomes are not supplied.

01 • Production manager: The report groups scrap and pending rework together. Why does that distinction matter for planning?

02 • Quality engineer: Scrap isn't recovered usable output. Pending rework still needs corrective work and acceptance checks before it counts as usable.

03 • Production manager: Can we count every unit awaiting rework as recovered output when we forecast supply?

04 • Quality engineer: No. Pending rework is not completed rework or an accepted final result.

05 • Production manager: What should the report show without inventing separate quantities we don't yet have?

06 • Quality engineer: Request the separate counts and distinguish scrap, pending rework, and any verified accepted output.

07 • Production manager: Would the total defect count still be useful once those categories are separated?

08 • Quality engineer: Yes, but it answers a different question from available supply or the workload remaining.

09 • Production manager: I'll keep containment status visible and ask the team to reconcile the categories.

10 • Quality engineer: I'll provide the verified breakdown and avoid treating a proposed recovery path as a guaranteed production outcome.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Fifty units contained, five units confirmed defective

Separate fictional inspection case: 50 units are contained for review, with five units confirmed defective so far; inspection of the remaining 45 units is pending.

01 • Warehouse lead: We contained fifty units. Should the dashboard show fifty units confirmed defective?

02 • Quality inspector: No. Five units are confirmed defective, while the remaining forty-five units still await inspection.

03 • Warehouse lead: So containment defines the group held for review, not the number already found defective?

04 • Quality inspector: Exactly. It is important not to turn a precautionary scope into a confirmed defective-unit count.

05 • Warehouse lead: Could I release the other forty-five because no defect has been recorded for them yet?

06 • Quality inspector: No. Pending inspection is not a passing result or an authorized disposition.

07 • Warehouse lead: I'll show fifty contained, five confirmed defective, and forty-five inspection results pending.

08 • Quality inspector: Please keep those categories linked so the group isn't counted twice in the total.

09 • Warehouse lead: I'll request the next verified status before updating available inventory or rework planning.

10 • Quality inspector: I'll return the inspection and disposition information through the quality process without predicting how many will pass.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Rework finished, acceptance check not finished

Separate fictional production case: 18 units completed an authorized rework activity, but their subsequent acceptance checks have not been completed.

01 • Rework coordinator: The rework activity is finished for eighteen units. Can they count as accepted output?

02 • Quality reviewer: Their acceptance checks are still pending, so completion of rework doesn't establish final acceptance.

03 • Rework coordinator: Does that mean I should label all eighteen as scrap until inspection is finished?

04 • Quality reviewer: No. Pending acceptance and scrap are different statuses; don't replace one with the other.

05 • Rework coordinator: What wording best explains their current position in the production flow?

06 • Quality reviewer: Eighteen units reworked, awaiting acceptance checks. Keep availability conditional on the authorized outcome.

07 • Rework coordinator: I'll use that wording so planning sees both completed effort and remaining work.

08 • Quality reviewer: Good. It also prevents the reworked quantity from being mistaken for a confirmed recovery rate.

09 • Rework coordinator: Who should confirm the next status before the dispatch team makes a commitment?

10 • Quality reviewer: The responsible quality team will communicate the verified result and disposition through the established process.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Defects, Scrap, and Rework

A quality report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework. The manager needs to understand the different consequences.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Scrap and rework are different outcomes. Scrapped units will not return to the process as usable product; rework attempts to make units conform. I'll report their quantities separately.

Scenario 2 | One unit with two defects

A fictional inspection finds two defects on one unit and one defect on a second unit. The report says three defective units. Discuss the difference between defect count and defective-unit count before the daily meeting.

Role A: Quality analyst: explain the two counting methods using the supplied observations.

Role B: Production supervisor: confirm the corrected unit count and ask how both measures should be labeled.

Possible opening: We found three defects across two units, not three defective units.

Success checks

- State three defects and two affected units accurately.
- Keep the measures distinct and avoid double counting.
- Do not infer scrap, rework, or release from defect count alone.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to add the two measures together into one total quality-loss number.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Root Cause and Corrective Action

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A defect appears after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed. A team member names the supplier as the root cause.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

root cause - Underlying reason a problem occurred, not merely the visible symptom.

5 Whys - Root-cause method that repeatedly asks why a problem occurred until the team reaches a controllable underlying cause.

fishbone - A cause-and-effect diagram used to organize possible contributors to a problem.

8D - Eight-discipline problem-solving report used to contain a problem, identify root cause, implement corrective action, and prevent recurrence.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - B. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - C. The change must have caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - B. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - C. Across the service, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A supplier change is one hypothesis

Fictional root-cause review: a defect appeared after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed.

01 • Production engineer: The defect appeared after the supplier change. Can we name the supplier as the root cause?

02 • Quality lead: Not yet. Several process settings changed too, so timing alone doesn't isolate the cause.

03 • Production engineer: Would a fishbone diagram help us separate supplier and process explanations during the review?

04 • Quality lead: Yes, as a way to organize hypotheses, not as proof that any branch is correct.

05 • Production engineer: Could we use 5 Whys to force the discussion to end with one definite answer today?

06 • Quality lead: The questions should follow evidence. We shouldn't invent a causal chain to fill the template.

07 • Production engineer: I'll bring the change records and identify which conditions differed when the defect appeared.

08 • Quality lead: Please preserve the unknowns and distinguish immediate containment from a completed 8D investigation.

09 • Production engineer: Then the team can plan comparisons rather than assign blame from the sequence alone.

10 • Quality lead: Agreed. We'll state the supplier change as a hypothesis until the relevant evidence supports a conclusion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A repeated adjustment does not establish the cause

Separate fictional investigation: operators adjusted alignment after three separate defects, but no controlled comparison or verified cause exists.

01 • Maintenance analyst: Operators adjusted alignment after all three defects. Does that establish alignment as the root cause?

02 • Quality investigator: It establishes an action taken after the defects, not what originally caused them.

03 • Maintenance analyst: Could their repeated choice still be useful evidence for our fishbone discussion?

04 • Quality investigator: Yes. Ask what they observed and why they chose the adjustment, while keeping the explanation provisional.

05 • Maintenance analyst: Should we describe the adjustment as a confirmed corrective action in the 8D update?

06 • Quality investigator: Not as a proven cause-based solution. We need evidence of the relationship and effectiveness.

07 • Maintenance analyst: I'll preserve the action history without writing that the adjustment eliminated the defect.

08 • Quality investigator: Good. Also identify any other changes that accompanied the adjustment before interpreting the sequence.

09 • Maintenance analyst: I'll request those records and ask the operators for their observed findings.

10 • Quality investigator: Then we can examine the hypothesis without turning a repeated response into a demonstrated root cause.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A clean shift after a change is encouraging, not conclusive

Separate fictional corrective-action review: one shift reported no recurrence after a process change; only that shift's observation is available.

01 • Operations manager: We had no recurrence this shift. Can the corrective-action report say the problem is permanently solved?

02 • Quality engineer: One clean shift is an observation, but it doesn't establish permanent elimination of the cause.

03 • Operations manager: How should I acknowledge the encouraging result without overstating what it proves?

04 • Quality engineer: Say no recurrence was observed during that shift and describe the agreed effectiveness review as pending.

05 • Operations manager: Could we close the 8D simply because the change has been implemented?

06 • Quality engineer: Implementation and demonstrated effectiveness are different stages. Follow the established closure criteria.

07 • Operations manager: The case doesn't supply those criteria, so I shouldn't invent a required number of shifts.

08 • Quality engineer: Correct. Ask the action owner to confirm the applicable assessment plan.

09 • Operations manager: I'll report the limited observation and request the next review checkpoint from the owner.

10 • Quality engineer: I'll keep the evidence scope clear so a useful initial result doesn't become an unsupported universal claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Root Cause and Corrective Action

A defect appears after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed. A team member names the supplier as the root cause.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The timing makes the supplier change worth examining, but other settings changed too. It is a hypothesis, not an established root cause. Let's compare the evidence before closing the investigation.

Scenario 2 | Two changed conditions in the successful trial

A fictional defect trial changed both material storage and machine setup; the trial produced no observed defects. The team wants to credit storage alone. Discuss what the trial can establish and what comparison remains needed.

Role A: Process engineer: describe both changed conditions and the observed result.

Role B: Quality investigator: challenge the single-cause conclusion and propose a reviewed evidence-gathering step.

Possible opening: Both storage and setup changed, so this result doesn't isolate storage as the cause.

Success checks

- Keep both changed conditions visible.
- Distinguish the observed trial result from a causal conclusion.
- Agree further assessment without prescribing an unsafe process experiment.

Add a complication: The meeting chair wants one root cause entered before lunch regardless of the evidence.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

A planned maintenance window conflicts with a rush order. The maintenance team needs to explain the available options to the decision maker.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

preventive maintenance - Planned work intended to reduce failures and maintain equipment condition.

MTBF - Mean time between failures: average operating time between failures for a defined repairable system.

changeover - The work and time needed to switch equipment or a line to another product or setup.

spare parts - Replacement components kept available for maintenance or repair.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Compare this wording: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - B. If the scope will change, we will review the schedule.
 - C. If the scope changes, we reviewed the schedule.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - B. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.
 - C. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A rush order overlaps planned maintenance

Fictional scheduling negotiation: a rush order overlaps a planned maintenance window; no authorization to defer maintenance or spare capacity is confirmed.

01 • Production planner: The rush order overlaps the maintenance window. Could we postpone preventive maintenance to finish the order?

02 • Maintenance lead: We need the authorized assessment first. I can't assume deferral is acceptable for this equipment.

03 • Production planner: What options can we bring to the decision maker without overriding that boundary?

04 • Maintenance lead: Assess the order timing, any verified alternate capacity, and the maintenance team's permitted scheduling options.

05 • Production planner: Could we promise another line while its capacity and changeover requirements are still unknown?

06 • Maintenance lead: No. Present that as an option requiring confirmation, not available capacity.

07 • Production planner: I'll ask sales which delivery flexibility exists and keep the maintenance dependency explicit.

08 • Maintenance lead: I'll request the authorized timing assessment and identify any spare-parts dependency affecting the window.

09 • Production planner: Then we'll compare confirmed options before offering the customer a revised commitment.

10 • Maintenance lead: Agreed. We can negotiate the plan while leaving equipment and safety decisions with the responsible specialists.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A spare part has an estimate, not a confirmed arrival

Separate fictional maintenance plan: a required spare part has an estimated Tuesday delivery; the carrier has not confirmed arrival, and the maintenance window is Wednesday.

01 • Maintenance scheduler: The spare part is estimated for Tuesday, ahead of Wednesday's window, but arrival isn't confirmed.

02 • Production manager: Can we commit to a Wednesday completion so I can promise Thursday output?

03 • Maintenance scheduler: That would depend on part receipt and the authorized maintenance assessment, neither settled by the estimate.

04 • Production manager: What conditional plan can we discuss with the team instead of leaving the whole schedule blank?

05 • Maintenance scheduler: Keep Wednesday as planned, subject to confirmed readiness, and agree when to review the part status.

06 • Production manager: Could a different part be substituted if the delivery slips by a day?

07 • Maintenance scheduler: Only through the appropriate technical approval; we shouldn't negotiate an unassessed substitution here.

08 • Production manager: I'll explain the dependency and request a delivery confirmation before the planning checkpoint.

09 • Maintenance scheduler: I'll coordinate readiness information and avoid treating a forecast arrival as a completed maintenance input.

10 • Production manager: Then we'll update output commitments from verified conditions rather than a chain of optimistic assumptions.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Changeover timing with an unconfirmed extra order

Separate fictional planning case: a changeover is planned after order A; sales proposes adding order B first, but B's quantity and due date are unconfirmed.

01 • Sales coordinator: Could you delay the changeover and fit order B after A before switching products?

02 • Production scheduler: We can assess that, but B's quantity and required date haven't been confirmed.

03 • Sales coordinator: Keeping the current setup sounds efficient. Can we agree now and settle quantity later?

04 • Production scheduler: The benefit and impact depend on quantity, capacity, and the next scheduled order.

05 • Sales coordinator: What information would let you offer a useful tradeoff at the planning meeting?

06 • Production scheduler: Confirm B's scope and timing, then we can compare the changeover sequence and downstream commitments.

07 • Sales coordinator: I'll ask whether partial delivery is acceptable without promising that the line can provide it.

08 • Production scheduler: Good. We'll also retain any maintenance constraints rather than treat sequence flexibility as unlimited.

09 • Sales coordinator: I'll return the confirmed request before asking for a revised production commitment.

10 • Production scheduler: I'll assess the options with the responsible team and state the conditions attached to any feasible plan.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

A planned maintenance window conflicts with a rush order. The maintenance team needs to explain the available options to the decision maker.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: The rush order and maintenance window compete for the same equipment. Could we review the approved options, expected production impact, and reliability concerns together before changing the plan?

Scenario 2 | A reliability average used to justify deferral

A fictional planning slide cites an equipment MTBF figure but gives no maintenance recommendation. A manager wants to use it to postpone a scheduled task. Practice explaining that mean time between failures is not itself authorization to defer work.

Role A: Maintenance planner: explain the distinction and request the authorized assessment.

Role B: Production manager: describe the schedule pressure and discuss conditional alternatives.

Possible opening: The MTBF figure summarizes reliability history; it does not by itself authorize postponing this task.

Success checks

- Do not convert an average into a no-failure promise.
- Keep maintenance authority with the responsible specialists.
- Agree to assess schedule options under explicit conditions.

Add a complication: The manager asks you to guarantee that nothing will fail during the delay.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

EHS and Safety Communication

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

During a safety exercise, a learner notices an unclear equipment-isolation instruction. The local approved procedure must govern the work.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

EHS - Environment, health, and safety: organizational functions addressing environmental and workplace risks.

lockout/tagout - Procedures for controlling hazardous energy during specified work; actual steps must follow approved safety requirements.

near miss - An event that could have caused harm but did not result in the specified harmful outcome.

stop work - A call or authorized action to pause work when a safety concern requires attention under local procedures.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - B. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - C. Send it no later than Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - B. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - C. Could you confirm that the review is important?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An unclear isolation instruction before work begins

Fictional safety-communication exercise: an equipment-isolation instruction is ambiguous, no work has begun, and the local approved procedure must govern the task.

01 • Maintenance technician: This isolation instruction is unclear. I need the authorized supervisor to clarify it before the task proceeds.

02 • Safety supervisor: Which wording is ambiguous, and have you identified the approved procedure for this equipment?

03 • Maintenance technician: The instruction doesn't identify the equipment reference clearly. I won't guess the intended machine.

04 • Safety supervisor: Good. We need the correct reference and applicable lockout/tagout procedure, not an improvised interpretation.

05 • Maintenance technician: Can you take the clarification request and confirm who is authorized to resolve it?

06 • Safety supervisor: Yes. I'll coordinate that check through our local safety process.

07 • Maintenance technician: Should I treat a coworker's memory as a substitute while the document is checked?

08 • Safety supervisor: No. This exercise calls for clarification through the approved route before proceeding, not operational shortcuts.

09 • Maintenance technician: I'll keep the task pending and provide the exact instruction reference for review.

10 • Safety supervisor: Request received. I'll return the verified clarification and keep equipment decisions with the authorized team.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A near-miss report needs the location clarified

Separate fictional EHS reporting exercise: a near miss is reported near a loading area, but the exact location is missing and no injury is reported in the supplied account.

01 • Warehouse supervisor: The report says near the loading area. Could you clarify the location before we route the follow-up?

02 • EHS coordinator: I'll request the specific location from the reporter and preserve the current account as incomplete.

03 • Warehouse supervisor: Can we enter bay four because it is the busiest bay on this shift?

04 • EHS coordinator: No. That would invent an event detail and could send the review to the wrong area.

05 • Warehouse supervisor: Please also confirm which responsible team should receive the report through our safety process.

06 • EHS coordinator: I will. The absence of an injury in the account doesn't remove the need for the reporting review.

07 • Warehouse supervisor: Should the briefing state that the area is now safe because the event ended?

08 • EHS coordinator: No assessment supporting that assurance is supplied here. Keep the known event separate from current safety status.

09 • Warehouse supervisor: I'll request a verified location and avoid adding a cause or safety conclusion.

10 • EHS coordinator: I'll acknowledge the handoff and arrange the appropriate follow-up under the local EHS process.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A stop-work concern needs a named receiver

Separate fictional safety drill: a technician raises a stop-work concern about conflicting task instructions, but no supervisor has acknowledged it; no operating steps are supplied.

01 • Technician: I've raised a stop-work concern about conflicting instructions, but I haven't received an acknowledgment.

02 • Shift supervisor: Please state the conflict clearly so I can receive the concern and route it appropriately.

03 • Technician: The two task sheets identify different equipment references. I need confirmation of the applicable instruction.

04 • Shift supervisor: Understood. We'll use the local approved process to resolve the conflict before the task proceeds.

05 • Technician: Can you confirm that you're accepting the clarification request, not simply noting that I called?

06 • Shift supervisor: Yes. I'll coordinate the authorized review and confirm the responsible decision maker.

07 • Technician: A colleague wants to choose the sheet with the newer print date. Is that verification?

08 • Shift supervisor: Not by itself. A print date doesn't establish which approved instruction governs this task.

09 • Technician: I'll preserve both references and keep the conflict visible in the handoff.

10 • Shift supervisor: Good. We'll return a verified instruction through the proper route rather than settle an equipment-safety question by guesswork.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | EHS and Safety Communication

During a safety exercise, a learner notices an unclear equipment-isolation instruction. The local approved procedure must govern the work.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: I need clarification of this instruction before the task proceeds. Please involve the authorized person and use the approved safety procedure. I will point out exactly which instruction is unclear.

Scenario 2 | A safety notice with an unreadable equipment number

In a fictional safety exercise, a posted notice refers to an equipment number that cannot be read. A scheduled task may involve that equipment, but the match is unconfirmed. Request clarification through the local approved process before proceeding.

Role A: Maintenance technician: identify the unreadable reference and request an authorized check.

Role B: EHS supervisor: confirm receipt and arrange clarification without guessing the number.

Possible opening: I can't read the equipment reference on this notice, so I need confirmation before the scheduled task proceeds.

Success checks

- State the precise uncertainty.
- Do not infer the notice is irrelevant or give operational isolation steps.
- Confirm the authorized review route and receiving owner.

Add a complication: A colleague says the notice probably concerns another machine and suggests ignoring it.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

An incoming inspection report cites a dimension without identifying the drawing revision. The supplier used a different revision.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

supplier quality - How well supplied goods and supplier processes meet specified requirements.

incoming inspection - A check of received materials or components against specified requirements.

specification - A detailed statement of required characteristics, performance, or materials.

deviation - A departure from an approved process, requirement, or expected condition.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An inspection dimension without a drawing revision

Fictional supplier-quality call: an incoming report cites a dimension but omits the drawing revision; the supplier used a different revision.

01 • Supplier quality engineer: The incoming report cites a dimension without the drawing revision. Which specification was the inspection based on?

02 • Supplier representative: Our team used a different revision from the one your inspector mentioned verbally.

03 • Supplier quality engineer: Before discussing a deviation, we need the controlling requirement and both source references confirmed.

04 • Supplier representative: Could we accept the newer-looking drawing because it would resolve the disagreement quickly?

05 • Supplier quality engineer: Appearance or print date doesn't establish the controlling revision for this order.

06 • Supplier representative: I'll provide the drawing reference used for production and the order documentation available to us.

07 • Supplier quality engineer: I'll request the inspection source and verify the applicable specification through document control.

08 • Supplier representative: Should either team label the lot conforming or nonconforming before that clarification is complete?

09 • Supplier quality engineer: We shouldn't invent a conclusion from the conflicting references; disposition remains with the authorized quality process.

10 • Supplier representative: Agreed. We'll compare the verified requirement and measurement evidence before resolving the reported difference.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Millimeters or inches on the supplier report?

Separate fictional incoming inspection: a supplier report lists a dimension as 2.5 without a unit; the receiving specification uses millimeters.

01 • Incoming inspector: Your report lists two point five but no unit. Could you confirm the measurement unit used?

02 • Supplier technician: I need to check the original record rather than assume it matches your millimeter specification.

03 • Incoming inspector: Thank you. A bare number doesn't let us compare the result reliably with the requirement.

04 • Supplier technician: Could you convert it as inches while I look for the record, just to keep inspection moving?

05 • Incoming inspector: No. That would base the assessment on an unverified unit and could change the conclusion.

06 • Supplier technician: I'll retrieve the source measurement and ask for a corrected report with the unit stated.

07 • Incoming inspector: Please include the applicable specification reference and drawing revision in that clarification.

08 • Supplier technician: Understood. I won't describe the lot as accepted just because the numerical value looks familiar.

09 • Incoming inspector: I'll keep the comparison pending and pass the verified information to the responsible quality reviewer.

10 • Supplier technician: I'll return the source-backed correction so the decision rests on the actual measurement rather than a guessed conversion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A deviation request is not an approved exception

Separate fictional supplier discussion: a supplier submitted a deviation request for lot M6, but the receiving team has no approval record.

01 • Buyer: The supplier sent a deviation request for M6. Does that mean the specification exception is approved?

02 • Supplier quality lead: No. We have a request, but no verified authorization for the exception.

03 • Buyer: Which question should I ask before I give production an update on the lot?

04 • Supplier quality lead: Ask for the review status, the precise scope requested, and the responsible approval record if one exists.

05 • Buyer: Could we assume approval applies to future lots as well if M6 eventually receives it?

06 • Supplier quality lead: Not without the actual authorized scope. A specific exception shouldn't become a blanket specification change.

07 • Buyer: I'll distinguish requested from approved and keep the M6 reference in every status message.

08 • Supplier quality lead: Please also avoid treating supplier acknowledgment as confirmation from our quality decision maker.

09 • Buyer: I'll request the verified status and leave the material commitment conditional.

10 • Supplier quality lead: I'll review the returned information through the appropriate process and clarify any limits before the status is communicated further.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

An incoming inspection report cites a dimension without identifying the drawing revision. The supplier used a different revision.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which drawing revision applies to this delivery? Let's record both references and ask the responsible quality team to resolve the discrepancy before we describe the material as conforming.

Scenario 2 | A certificate refers to the wrong order

A fictional incoming lot has a certificate naming purchase order 418, while the delivery paperwork names 481. The material identity has not been reconciled. Clarify the mismatch before using the certificate as evidence.

Role A: Incoming quality coordinator: identify the two order references and request verification.

Role B: Supplier documentation specialist: check the source records without assuming a typing error.

Possible opening: The certificate says 418 and the delivery says 481; could you verify which order this certificate supports?

Success checks

- State both references accurately.
- Do not assume a typographical error or alter supplier evidence informally.
- Agree a source-backed clarification and preserve lot traceability.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests changing the digits locally because the numbers look transposed.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Shift Handoffs and Escalation

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

The outgoing shift has completed six of eight checks. Two checks remain open, with records attached and a named incoming supervisor.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

handoff - Transfer of work, responsibility, information, or risk from one person or team to another.

andon - A visual or audible production signal that draws attention to status or a problem.

escalation - Raising an issue to a higher authority or different function because risk, urgency, or decision rights require it.

owner - Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Compare this wording: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
 - B. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - C. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.
 - B. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - C. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Six checks complete, two handed over

Fictional shift handoff: six of eight checks are complete, check seven (label reconciliation) and check eight (container-count review) remain open, records are attached, and incoming supervisor Lee is the named receiver.

01 • Outgoing supervisor: Lee, six of the eight checks are complete. Two remain open, with the records attached.

02 • Incoming supervisor Lee: Which status should I communicate before I review the open items with the team?

03 • Outgoing supervisor: Six complete, two pending. Don't describe the checklist as finished or imply an authorized production decision.

04 • Incoming supervisor Lee: Do the attached records identify the open checks, or do I need another source?

05 • Outgoing supervisor: Check seven is label reconciliation; check eight is container-count review. Both are open, with supporting records attached.

06 • Incoming supervisor Lee: I'll take ownership of reviewing the two open items and confirming the appropriate next action.

07 • Outgoing supervisor: Please read back the completion count so we know the transfer is clear.

08 • Incoming supervisor Lee: Six complete; label reconciliation and container-count review remain open. I own their follow-up.

09 • Outgoing supervisor: Correct. Any concern needing escalation should follow our established route rather than remain only in this conversation.

10 • Incoming supervisor Lee: Handoff accepted. I'll confirm the verified status after reviewing the records with the responsible team.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An andon call acknowledged but unresolved

Separate fictional shift handoff: an andon call for line C was acknowledged at 13:40, but no resolution is recorded; incoming line leader Noor will follow up.

01 • Outgoing line leader: Line C's andon call was acknowledged at thirteen forty, but no resolution is recorded.

02 • Incoming line leader Noor: So acknowledgment tells us someone received the call, not that the underlying issue is resolved?

03 • Outgoing line leader: Exactly. Please keep those two statuses separate when you brief the incoming team.

04 • Incoming line leader Noor: Do we have enough information to say why the line raised the call?

05 • Outgoing line leader: The reason isn't supplied in this handoff summary. You'll need the actual call record to verify it.

06 • Incoming line leader Noor: I'll own that follow-up and confirm the responsible responder through the escalation process.

07 • Outgoing line leader: Please don't mark the issue closed merely because the alert has been acknowledged.

08 • Incoming line leader Noor: Understood: line C, acknowledgment at thirteen forty, resolution unconfirmed, follow-up assigned to me.

09 • Outgoing line leader: That's correct. I'll remain available to clarify the outgoing shift's documented actions.

10 • Incoming line leader Noor: I'll return the verified status and pass any unresolved concern through the appropriate escalation route.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A quality hold must survive the shift change

Separate fictional handoff: pallet P9 remains on quality hold; investigation is pending, and no release has been authorized. Incoming warehouse supervisor Chen receives the handoff.

01 • Outgoing warehouse supervisor: Pallet P9 remains on quality hold. Investigation is pending, and no release is authorized.

02 • Incoming supervisor Chen: The dispatch list includes P9. Does being on that list change the hold status?

03 • Outgoing warehouse supervisor: No. A planned dispatch entry isn't a quality release or a change in disposition.

04 • Incoming supervisor Chen: I'll flag the conflict to dispatch and maintain the verified hold status through our process.

05 • Outgoing warehouse supervisor: Please confirm who will seek the next quality update so the issue has a clear owner.

06 • Incoming supervisor Chen: I'll own that follow-up and contact the responsible quality team for a verified status.

07 • Outgoing warehouse supervisor: Don't infer release from silence if the team hasn't responded before the truck arrives.

08 • Incoming supervisor Chen: Understood. P9 remains held, and the dispatch conflict needs escalation if unresolved.

09 • Outgoing warehouse supervisor: That's the handoff. The record reference is P9, and I haven't promised an investigation outcome.

10 • Incoming supervisor Chen: Accepted. I'll communicate the confirmed status and keep dispatch planning separate from release authority.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Shift Handoffs and Escalation

The outgoing shift has completed six of eight checks. Two checks remain open, with records attached and a named incoming supervisor.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: Six checks are complete; two remain open. The records show what has been checked and what is pending. Please confirm that the incoming supervisor has accepted the follow-up tasks.

Scenario 2 | An unfinished count handed to the next shift

A fictional shift counted 70 of 100 containers. Thirty remain unchecked, and no discrepancy has yet been established. Incoming supervisor Rosa is the named receiver. Practice transferring the count status and follow-up responsibility.

Role A: Outgoing supervisor: state the checked and unchecked quantities without declaring the inventory reconciled.

Role B: Incoming supervisor Rosa: read back the remaining work and accept the next count-status update.

Possible opening: Seventy containers are checked; thirty remain, so the count is not yet complete.

Success checks

- Distinguish unchecked from missing.
- Read back seventy complete and thirty pending.
- Confirm Rosa's follow-up ownership without predicting the final count result.

Add a complication: A planner asks you to classify the thirty unchecked containers as missing.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Production Flow and Daily Management

Editing example: Three checks are complete; two remain open and are being reviewed.

The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Check 1: B - The team has completed the review.

A: 'Plans to complete' describes an intention, not completion.

B: 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

C: 'Is completing' presents the work as in progress.

Check 2: A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

A: This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

B: A plan does not establish carrier confirmation.

C: A plan cannot prove a future arrival time.

Model response: Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

Editing example: The last two reports omitted the agreed summary section.

The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Check 1: A - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date.

A: The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.

B: "Less professional" is an evaluation; it does not identify a specific observable omission.

C: Commitment is an interpretation, not a description of what the updates contained.

Check 2: C - What is making this part of the task difficult?

A: A promise does not reveal the obstacle or what support would help.

B: This proposes a solution before finding out what is making the task difficult.

C: An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

Model response: The observed delay occurs while people wait for shared tools. Let's examine tool availability and layout before attributing the issue to individual speed. Could we test a revised arrangement?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Defects, Scrap, and Rework

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

B: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

C: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

Check 2: B - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

B: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

C: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

Model response: Scrap and rework are different outcomes. Scrapped units will not return to the process as usable product; rework attempts to make units conform. I'll report their quantities separately.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Root Cause and Corrective Action

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: B - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

B: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

C: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

Check 2: A - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

B: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

C: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

Model response: The timing makes the supplier change worth examining, but other settings changed too. It is a hypothesis, not an established root cause. Let's compare the evidence before closing the investigation.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

B: For this ordinary future condition, use present simple in the "if" clause.

C: "Reviewed" places the response in the past instead of expressing the future response.

Check 2: C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

B: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

C: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

Model response: The rush order and maintenance window compete for the same equipment. Could we review the approved options, expected production impact, and reliability concerns together before changing the plan?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | EHS and Safety Communication

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: C - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

B: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

C: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

Check 2: B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

B: The requested action and information are explicit.

C: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

Model response: I need clarification of this instruction before the task proceeds. Please involve the authorized person and use the approved safety procedure. I will point out exactly which instruction is unclear.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: Which drawing revision applies to this delivery? Let's record both references and ask the responsible quality team to resolve the discrepancy before we describe the material as conforming.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Shift Handoffs and Escalation

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

B: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

C: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

Check 2: C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: It changes pending information into a final result.

B: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

C: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

Model response: Six checks are complete; two remain open. The records show what has been checked and what is pending. Please confirm that the incoming supervisor has accepted the follow-up tasks.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Manufacturing English

Professional audience: plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals

Scope: These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Lesson 01: Production Flow and Daily Management

Original fictional case: A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Language workshop: Give a useful status update

Communication goal: Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

Language guidance: Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): We have completed ...; ... remains open. / As of ..., the status is / The next update will cover

Vocabulary: throughput: Amount of work, patients, goods, cases, or transactions completed in a period of time. / cycle time: The time needed to complete one defined production or work cycle. / constraint: A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible. / downtime: Time during which equipment or a service is unavailable for its intended work.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level